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KABULIWALLAH

A BRIEF HISTORY OF INDIA-AFGHANISTAN RELATIONS

'Kabuliwala has done more to give us [Afghanistan] a brand which we could not buy with a billion dollars of advertisements.'

Mohammad Ashraf Ghani, President of the Islamic Republic of Afghanistan, 2015.[1]

An emotional bond

Rahmud, the great Kabuliwallah, or 'fruit-seller from Kabul', became good friends with little Mini. Love and longing for home and his daughter, who was Mini's age, sparked a fascinating bond between the tall, bearded 'Pathan' and the little Bengali child. His patient listening, quick wit, and loving gifts quickly overcame Mini's fears that the Kabuliwallah would bundle her up in his large bag, which could easily fit two or three children.[2] The developing friendship met an abrupt end one day when Rahmud was arrested over charges of assault. Unwilling to tolerate an insult, he had stabbed one of his customers. Years later, when Rahmud got out of prison, he would return to meet his little friend. But whom he will meet is not the talkative, carefree child but a shy and beautiful young woman on her wedding day. As Rabindranath Tagore put it, 'the Cabuliwallah